

For all enquiries or if you would like your name added to the letter, please email bbcmecoverage@gmail.com

An Open Letter to BBC Management, Written by BBC Journalists and Signed by Media Industry Professionals

A message to the BBC Director General, the Board of Governors and our BBC Colleagues.

We're writing to express our concerns over opaque editorial decisions and censorship at the BBC on the reporting of Israel/Palestine. We believe the refusal to broadcast the documentary 'Gaza: Medics Under Fire' is just one in a long line of agenda driven decisions. It demonstrates, once again, that the BBC is not reporting "without fear or favour" when it comes to Israel.

We understand that a decision not to broadcast the investigation has been taken by senior BBC management despite the film's content being signed off in accordance with BBC guidelines and editorial policy. This appears to be a political decision and is not reflective of the journalism in the film. A recent statement from the BBC said broadcasting the film "risked creating the perception of partiality". This illustrates precisely what many of us have experienced first hand: an organisation that is crippled by the fear of being perceived as critical of the Israeli government.

We are not asking the BBC to take a side. We are asking to be allowed to do our jobs in delivering facts transparently and with due context. For many of us, our efforts have been frustrated by opaque decisions made at senior levels of the BBC without discussion or explanation. Our failures impact audiences. As an organisation we have not offered any significant analysis of the UK government's involvement in the war on Palestinians. We have failed to report on weapons sales or their legal implications. These stories have instead been broken by the BBC's competitors.

This hasn't happened by accident, rather by design. Much of the BBC's coverage in this area is defined by anti-Palestinian racism. The inconsistent manner in which guidance is applied draws into focus the role of Sir Robbie Gibb, on the BBC Board and BBC's Editorial Standards Committee. We are concerned that an individual with close ties to the Jewish Chronicle, an outlet that has repeatedly published anti-Palestinian and often racist content, has a say in the BBC's editorial decisions in any capacity, including the decision not to broadcast 'Gaza: Medics Under Fire'.

This conflict of interest highlights a double standard for BBC content makers who have themselves experienced censorship in the name of 'impartiality'. In some instances staff have been accused of having an agenda because they have posted news articles critical of the Israeli government on their social media. By comparison, Gibb remains in an influential post with little transparency regarding his decisions despite his ideological leanings being well known. We can no longer ask license fee payers to overlook Gibbs' ideological allegiances.

Since October 2023 it has become increasingly clear to our audiences that the BBC's reporting on Israel / Palestine falls short of our own editorial standards. There is a gulf between the BBC's coverage of what is happening in Gaza and the West Bank and what our audiences can see is happening via multiple credible sources including human rights organisations, staff at the UN and journalists on the ground. Whilst there has been some exceptional content from some areas of the BBC (within documentary and from some individual correspondents for example), news in particular has failed to report the reality and the context of the war on Palestinians. All too often it has felt that the BBC has been performing PR for the Israeli government and military. This should be a cause of great shame and concern for everyone at the BBC.

Despite these failings, there has been a major shift within public discourse in recent months. Increasingly the scale of Israel's crimes against the Palestinians are being understood by the public as well as many of our parliamentarians. The BBC's editorial decisions seem increasingly out of step with reality. We have been forced to conclude that decisions are made to fit a political agenda rather than serve the needs of audiences. As industry insiders and as BBC staff, we have experienced this first hand. The issue has become even more urgent with recent escalations in the region. Again, BBC coverage has appeared to downplay Israel's role, reinforcing an 'Israel first' framing that compromises our credibility.

We, the undersigned BBC staff, freelancers and industry figures are extremely concerned that the BBC's reporting on Israel and Palestine continues to fall short of the standards our audiences expect. We believe the role of Robbie Gibb, both on the Board, and as part of the Editorial Standards Committee, is untenable. We call on the BBC to do better for our audiences and recommit to our values of impartiality, honesty and reporting without fear or favour.

END

Signed by:

121 BBC Journalists

Anonymous, BBC World Service
Anonymous, Senior Journalist, BBC World Service
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Anonymous, BBC Executive
Anonymous, BBC World Service
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Anonymous, BBC News Arabic
Anonymous, BBC Digital
Anonymous, BBC News
Anonymous, BBC Digital
Anonymous, BBC iPlayer
Anonymous, BBC Arabic
Anonymous, BBC News
Anonymous, BBC iPlayer
Anonymous, BBC iPlayer
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Anonymous, Senior Journalist, BBC News
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Anonymous, BBC Nations & Regions
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Anonymous, Journalist, BBC News
Anonymous, Assistant Editor, BBC World Service
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Anonymous, Journalist, BBC World Service
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Anonymous, Journalist, BBC News
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Anonymous, BBC Panorama
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Anonymous, BBC News
Anonymous, BBC Nations & Regions
Anonymous, BBC World Service
Anonymous, BBC Arabic
Anonymous, Journalist, BBC World Service
Anonymous, BBC News
Anonymous, Manager, BBC radio
Anonymous, Journalist, BBC World Service
Anonymous, BBC Content
Anonymous, Senior Journalist, BBC World Service
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Anonymous, Senior Journalist, BBC World Service
Anonymous, BBC World Service
Anonymous, BBC News

306 Media Industry Figures

Juliet Stevenson, Actor
Khalid Abdalla, Actor
Zawe Ashton, Actor
Dr Shola Mos-Shogbamimu, Author and Activist
Afua Hirsch, Writer and Broadcaster
Mike Leigh, Film Director
Miriam Margolyes, Actor and Presenter
William Dalrymple, Writer and Presenter
Owen Jones, Writer, The Guardian
Mariayah Kaderbhai, Director of Programmes
Ben de Pear, Founder of Basement Films and former Editor of Channel 4 News
Misan Harriman, Photographer
Farah Nabulsi, Filmmaker
Denise Gough, Actor
Alexei Sayle, Actor
Aiysha Hart, Actor

India Willoughby, Broadcaster
Rivkah Brown, Journalist
John Parker, Freelance Video Editor
Professor Des Freedman, Department of Media & Communications, Goldsmiths, University of London
Roger McKenzie, International Editor of the Morning Star
Tam Dean Burn, Actor
Daniel York Loh, Actor
Vivian Munn, Actor
Thusitha Jayasundera, Actor
Bilal Hasna, Actor
Dr Iain Overton, Author and lecturer in Journalism, Birkbeck, University of London
Salman Akhtar, Actor
Fionn Ó Loingsigh, Actor
Sara Masry, Actor and Writer
Lina Caicedo, Archive Producer
Sule Rimi, Actor
Professor Dina Matar, Political Communication and Arab Media, SOAS
Dr Zahera Harb, Journalism Academic and Writer
Dr Milly Williamson, Goldsmiths University of London
Jasleen Kaur Sethi, Director
George Newman, Producer
Rose Glandfield, Documentary Editor
Jessica Kelly, Freelance Filmmaker
Majdolin Hasan, Global Investigative Journalism Network
Claire Read, Long-form podcast editor, The Economist
Yousef Jubeh, Freelance Film Editor
Alia Ibrahim, Daraj Media
June Cross, Secret Daughter Productions
Alexander Durie, Freelance Journalist
Raman Mohial, Camera Operator
Hala Droubi, Journalist
Meriem el Boudadi, Media Analyst
Alex King, Freelance Journalist
Aina J Khan, Freelance Journalist
Selma Chalabi, Freelance Producer and Presenter
Dhruti Shah, Freelance Journalist
Mais Al-Bayaa, Freelance Journalist
Muhammad Elashiry, Freelance Writer
Nada-Mai Issa, Freelance Journalist and Filmmaker
Yas Almosawi, Freelance Editor
Nahed Najjar, Freelance Journalist
Horia El Hadad, Al Jazeera English
Satmohan Panesar, Freelance Creative Executive

Anabelle Marshall, Director
Laurie Kirwan-Ashman, Writer-director
Abla Kandalaft, ex BBC Arabic
Sophie Binyon, Freelance Producer
Chloe Massey, Voice Over Artist and Actor
Toral Dixit, Producer Director
Omar Bynon, Theatre-Maker
Farah Qayum, Producer Director
Nina Milns, Writer
Annie Siddons, Writer
Toby Clarkson, Editor
Amer Sultan, Middle East Monitor
Liam O'Hare, Freelance Director/Producer
Riffy Ahmed, Writer/Director
Catherine Happer, Glasgow University Media Group
Gholam Khiabany, Goldsmiths, University of London
Professor Catherine Rottenberg, Goldsmiths, University of London
Miriyaam Aouragh, Professor of Digital Anthropology, University of Westminster
Cesar Caldito, Al Jazeera English
Fred Henson, Blackleaf Films
Anjana Stephens, Assistant Producer
Hanna Flint, Journalist
Claire Eaton-Rutter, Journalist and Editor
Natalie Janicka, Production Co-ordinator
Adam Miller, Freelance Journalist
Ruth Lass, Actor
Emma Kelly, Freelance Journalist
Kwami Odoom, Actor
Vanessa Bowles, Freelancer Filmmaker
Jo Stone Fewings, Actor
Kevin Twomey, Presenter
Greg McHugh, Actor
Lucy Sheen, Actor
Elias Suhail, Director
Elias Millward, Production Manager
Bassel Ghandour, Producer
Bushra Siddiq, Development Producer
Ruth Sweeney, Producer
Jessica Lyne de Ver, Director
Mark Oosterveen, Actor/Writer/Director
Grant Keir, Film Producer
Min Molloy, Producer
Ellen E Jones, Writer and Broadcaster
Toby Parker Rees, Writer/Director

Lorine Plafnol, Film Producer
Richard Sanders, Freelance Film Director
Sophie Toumazis, Media Consultant
Judith Jacob, Actor
Elham Ehsas, Actor
Zoe Mello, Producer
Larry Ryan, Writer and Editor
Chris Beresford, Freelance Film Editor
Rick Politz, Freelance Producer Director
Havana Marking, Director
Norma Dixit, Actor
George Hughes, Filmmaker
Maria Norrman, Artist and Filmmaker
Dr. John A Smith, Freelance director
Ollie Craig, Director of Photography
Leo Fawkes, Director
Himesh Kar, Film Producer
Anna Griffin, Film Producer
Alethea Lindsay, Freelance Producer/Editor
Charlotte Bairsto, Producer
Danielle Hailstones, Editor
Florence Kennard, Freelance film editor
Abir Awad, Former BBC Staff
James Joseph Boyle, Actor
Rubia Dar, Producer/Director
Alina Kolosova, Filmmaker
Callum Macrae, Filmmaker
Hannah Kelso, Writer/Director
Shaista Aziz, Journalist
Alex Fry, Freelance Editor
Rebecca O'Brien, Film Producer
Lucy Conley, Actor
Tara Creme, Freelance Composer
Yacine Helali, Filmmaker
Nikita Lalwani, Screenwriter
Emma Partridge, Freelance Makeup Artist
Malcolm Garrett MBE RDI, Designer
Richard Melman, Freelance Executive Producer
Stephen Mulholland, Film Editor
Sue Carpenter, Independent filmmaker
Natasha Carpenter Ballard, Director of Development
Nisha Parti, Film Producer
Andin Ngwa, Development Executive
Siân Robins-Grace, Film Writer

Charlie Phillips, Documentary Producer
Lawrence Meads, Sound Operator
Mark Summers, Freelance Film Editor
Tanika Gupta, Writer
Lewis Peake, Concept Artist
Marianna Karakoulaki, Freelance Journalist
Uri Fruchtmann, Film Producer
Paul Ewen, writer
Hussina Raja, Actor
Heidi Perry, Ex. BBC Staff Producer/Director
Reece Cargan, Film Producer
Tara Kelly, Art Department
Prof Natalie Fenton, Goldsmiths University of London
Fionn Walton, Actor
Peter Brown, Retired Lawyer
India Amarteifio, Actor
Sasha Nathwani, Filmmaker
Amal Al-Agroobi, Filmmaker
Fran Robertson, Producer/Director
Ellena Wood, Freelance Director
Dima Hamdan, Film Director
Rebecca Lloyd-Evans, Film Director
Raisah Ahmed, Writer/Director
Paul Sng, Filmmaker
Wajeeha Sheikh, Assistant Producer
Ruhi Hamid, Filmmaker
Amrit Wilson, Freelance Journalist
Pamela Gordon, Director Producer
Archie Lauchlan, Independent Documentary Filmmaker
Thembi Mutch, Freelance Journalist
James Gold, Freelance Editor
Aysha Rafaele, Director /Exec Producer
Pooja Ghai, Artistic Director
Damian Paul Daniel, Cameraman
Elliot Barrett, First Assistant Editor
Polly Steele, Freelance Filmmaker
Karishma Patel, Journalist ex. BBC
Dr Michael Hrebeniak, Dept. of Culture, Communication & Media, UCL
Alan Hayling, Documentary Producer
Ellie Kendrick, Screenwriter
Olive James, Actor
Merilyn Moos, UCU
Marc Sorrentino, Company Director
Harry Williams , Writer and Producer

Professor Aisha K. Gill, University of Bristol
Paola dionisotti, Actor
Selma Dabbagh, Writer
Joth Shakerley, Photographer
Tahnee Shakerley, Marketing Manager
Mike Lerner, Producer
Lucy Miller, Freelance Actor, Writer, Director and Filmmaker
Charlotte Kilpatrick, Journalist
Louay Ismail, Executive Producer & Media Consultant
Jil Schaffner, Actor and Director
Ramzy Haddad, Producer and Director
Charlie Melville, Producer and Director
Shelley Gill, Talent Manager
Claudio Rojas, Retired Radio Programmes Producer
Jack Cocker, Producer and Director
Kate Morris, Freelance Journalist
Rohan Sudan, Development Co-ordinator
Alessandra Masi, Artist
Jenny Ash, Director
Jen Brister, Stand-up Comedian
Maegan Tillock, Producer
Jessi Gutch, Independent Filmmaker
Rosamund Walwin, Producer
Charles Dance, Actor
Allegra Donn, Freelance Journalist and Writer
Rakie Ayola, Actor
Hashim Alsaraf, Production Manager
Jeanette Calliva, PR Director
Talah Kaddourah, Producer
Colm Martin, Producer
Javier Farje, Freelance Senior Producer ex BBC World Service
Ciana O'Muireadhaigh, Composer
Elena Battista, Editor
Marcelo Justo, Journalist
Trevor Murphy, Film & TV Camera Department
Hannah Dakin, Photographer
Enos Desjardins, Sound Designer
Gaz Evans, Freelance Editor
Laura Fraser, Writer
Thomas Macnab, Series Director
Natasha Menon, Artist
María Esperanza Sánchez, Freelance Journalist
Paul Lee, Filmmaker and Producer
Faris Couri, Retired, Former BBC Editor

Patrick Richmond Nicholas, Photographer
Lora Ghany, University of the Arts London
Natalie Hill, Freelance Screenwriter
Dara Kell, Filmmaker
Catherine Meyburgh, Filmmaker
Edwin Angless, COO
Holly Falconer, Photographer
Karim Shah, Producer/Director
Geoff Arbourne, Producer
Eenan Ma, Irish Screen Editors Guild
Tarik Sabry, Academic
Kat Amara-korba, Producer
Sima Motamen-Samadian, Retired University Lecturer
Gabriella O'Donnell, Freelance Journalist and Ex BBC staffer
María Esperanza Sánchez, Freelance, ex BBC journalist
Carl Klink, AFP
Nicola Cutcher, Freelance Journalist and Documentary Filmmaker
Sara Afshar, Journalist and Filmmaker
Dr Robina Qureshi, CEO
Anonymous, Freelance Producer/Director
Anonymous, TV Presenter
Anonymous, Sky News
Anonymous, Freelance Video Editor
Anonymous, Investigative Journalist
Anonymous, Actor
Anonymous, Playwright
Anonymous, Documentary Producer
Anonymous, Film Producer
Anonymous, Metro
Anonymous, Director
Anonymous, The Times & Sunday Times
Anonymous, Writer & Director
Anonymous, Journalist
Anonymous, Journalist
Anonymous, Film Producer
Anonymous, Assistant Producer
Anonymous, The Times
Anonymous, Freelance Editor
Anonymous, Actor
Anonymous, Director
Anonymous, Production Designer
Anonymous, Editor
Anonymous, Assistant Producer
Anonymous, Freelance writer and former BBC producer

Anonymous, Consultant
Anonymous, Second Assistant Editor
Anonymous, Actress and Narrator
Anonymous, Artist
Anonymous, Actor
Anonymous, Events
Anonymous, Operations Assistant
Anonymous, Executive Director
Anonymous, Producer
Anonymous, Artist
Anonymous, Photographer
Anonymous, Executive Assistant
Anonymous, Journalist/Documentary Filmmaker
Anonymous, Freelance Journalist and Documentary Producer
Anonymous, Freelance Producer and Former Employee of BBC News
Anonymous, Director
Anonymous, Broadcaster
Anonymous, Camera Assistant and Photographer
Anonymous, Director, Writer and Producer
Anonymous, Journalist
Anonymous, Journalist
Anonymous, Journalist
Anonymous, Author
Anonymous, Actor
Anonymous, Actor
Anonymous, Playwright and screenwriter
Anonymous, Actor
Anonymous, Actor
Anonymous, Freelance Producer